



# TPM Academy Kickoff

Half-Day Orientation • Pre-Week 1

Technical Product Manager Academy



# Why This Half-Day Exists

An eight-week academy without a shared starting line tends to drift in week one. Today is the starting line.

- Name what a Technical Product Manager actually is — and isn't
- See the full arc of the eight weeks before Day 1 begins
- Form the **triads** you'll work with through Week 3's mini-capstone
- Agree on the ground rules: AI policy, notetaker policy, attendance, feedback
- Confirm everyone is technically ready for Monday



# This Morning's Shape

| Clock         | Block                                       | Outcome                        |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:30 | Welcome & Introductions                     | Faces, names, why-you're-here  |
| 09:30 – 10:30 | Block 1 — The TPM Role                      | Shared mental model of the job |
| 10:30 – 10:45 | <b>Break</b>                                |                                |
| 10:45 – 11:45 | Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation | Eight-week map; your triad     |
| 11:45 – 12:30 | Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 launch               | Ready to start Monday          |



# Activity 1 — Two Truths and a TPM

**Format:** Full room → pairs • 20 min

- Pair up with someone you've never worked with
- Each of you shares **three statements**: two true, one false — all about your product or engineering experience
- Partner guesses the false one and asks one follow-up question
- We'll surface the most surprising "truth" from each pair when we regroup

*Goal: leave the icebreaker with one new face you can put a story to.*

# Block 1 — The TPM Role

What you're actually signing up to do



# What is a Technical Product Manager?

A TPM owns the **outcome of a technically constrained product surface** — translating customer problems into engineering scope without losing either side of the translation.

- Lives at the intersection of **customer**, **system**, and **delivery**
- Owns a PRD that engineering can build and customers will value
- Reasons about latency, data shape, dependencies, and trade-offs — not just features
- Negotiates priorities with stakeholders who hold conflicting truths



# TPM vs PM vs EM

## Product Manager

- What and why
- Customer evidence, market positioning
- Outcome ownership across the product
- Often less technical depth

## Technical Product Manager

- What, why, **and feasible how**
- Customer evidence + system constraints
- Often owns API/platform/infra surfaces
- Speaks both languages fluently

## Engineering Manager

- How and who
- People, delivery, technical execution quality
- Owns engineering capacity and team health



# The Five Sibling Artifacts

By Week 5 you'll have written each of these at least once:

| Artifact                                   | Question it answers                        | Owner of the truth |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>PRD</b> — Product Requirements Document | What are we building and why?              | TPM                |
| <b>TCD</b> — Technical Concept Document    | What is the high-level system shape?       | TPM + Architect    |
| <b>TMD</b> — Technical Modeling Document   | What are the data and component models?    | TPM + Tech Lead    |
| <b>SEP</b> — Stakeholder Engagement Plan   | Who is impacted and how do we engage them? | TPM                |
| <b>DP</b> — Delivery Plan                  | How will we ship and measure?              | TPM + EM           |





## Where TPMs Tend to Fail

- **Pre-deciding the solution.** Walking in with the answer instead of the problem.
- **Misreading constraints.** Treating "we've never built that" as "we can't build that."
- **Hiding behind technical detail.** Using diagrams to dodge customer-value questions.
- **Hiding behind customer empathy.** Using personas to dodge technical accountability.
- **Owning every artifact alone.** The five sibling artifacts are *collaborative*, not solo writing exercises.

# Activity 2 — "Where Have You Seen a TPM Win or Lose?"

**Format:** Quartets • 30 min

- Each person writes a 60-second story: a real TPM (or PM doing TPM work) you saw *win* or *lose* a decision
- Read silently around the table — no narration
- The quartet picks **one** story and identifies which failure mode (or its inverse) was in play
- One quartet per readout: 90 seconds each

*Deliverable: a tagged story per quartet, surfaced to the room.*



# Break

15 minutes — be back at 10:45

# Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation

Where this is going, and who you're going with



# The Eight-Week Map

| Week | Theme                                | Capstone moment                            |
|------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Customer-Centric Foundations         | —                                          |
| 2    | Strategic Design & Metrics           | —                                          |
| 3    | Requirements Engineering             | <b>Mini-capstone PRD + peer review</b>     |
| 4    | Technical Architecture & Constraints | —                                          |
| 5    | Technical Infrastructure & Modeling  | —                                          |
| 6    | Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation  | —                                          |
| 7    | Agile Delivery & ADO Mastery         | —                                          |
| 8    | AI Spec Development & Capstone       | <b>Real-world capstone + presentations</b> |



# The Capstone Arc

## Week 3 Mini-Capstone

- Triad-built PRD
- Running case study: **FieldPulse** (HVAC dispatch SaaS)
- Peer review on Friday — every triad reads every other triad
- AI tools off — honor system

## Week 8 Final Capstone

- Real product / problem you bring
- Full set of 5 sibling artifacts
- Friday: 12-minute presentation + Q&A
- AI tools on with validation discipline

# The AI Policy in One Sentence

AI tools are **part of the curriculum, not a shortcut around it** — except Week 3, where they are explicitly off so the muscle of unaided requirements writing gets built.

- Weeks 1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 — AI is in scope; validation discipline is required
- Week 3 — AI off in your editor, off in your browser, honor system
- Every AI-assisted artifact gets a **provenance note**: prompts used, what was kept, what was discarded



# What You'll Use Day to Day

- **Markdown editor** with live preview (Obsidian / VS Code + MPE / Typora)
- **Two AI assistants** — Claude and ChatGPT are the most common; verify your access before Monday
- **Browser** for the academy repo, decks, and the SkillIQ assessments
- **Diagramming tool** — Miro / Lucidchart / Excalidraw / whiteboard
- **Azure DevOps** — Week 7 only; we'll confirm access before then

Full setup instructions are in `participant-setup/TECH-SETUP.md`.





# Triads — The Heart of the Cohort

- Three participants per triad — fixed through end of Week 3
- Every activity is run in triad unless otherwise marked
- Triads carry the Week 3 mini-capstone PRD together
- Composition rules: mix experience levels, mix domain backgrounds, no same-home-team pairs where possible
- Triads reshuffle for Weeks 4–8

# Activity 3 — Triad Formation + First Commitment

**Format:** Self-organize → triads • 25 min

- Stand. Find two people with at least one *different* dimension from you: experience level, domain, or home team
- Sit together. You are a triad through end of Week 3
- Write a **one-sentence triad commitment** — something like: "We will tell each other when our drafts are weak, before peer review tells us"
- Share triad names + commitments with the room — 30 seconds per triad

*Deliverable: a named triad and a written commitment, on a single index card.*

# Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 Launch

The last 45 minutes



# Daily Rhythm Starting Monday

| Block                                | Duration |
|--------------------------------------|----------|
| Opening & objectives                 | 0:15     |
| Teaching Block 1 + Activity 1        | 1:15     |
| <b>Morning break</b>                 | 0:15     |
| Teaching Block 2 + Activity 2        | 1:15     |
| <b>Lunch</b>                         | 1:00     |
| Teaching Block 3 + Activity 3        | 1:15     |
| <b>Afternoon break</b>               | 0:15     |
| Teaching Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap | 1:30     |

# Feedback & Channels

## During the academy

- Daily anonymous pulse — one click, end of day
- Triad-internal: keep it direct, low-stakes
- Direct to instructor: any time, any channel

## End of each week

- Friday 15-minute retrospective — what worked / what to adjust
- End-of-week pulse survey
- Adjustments visible by Monday



# What to Bring Monday

- Laptop with markdown editor + browser + AI assistant access — all verified
- A real product you ship to today (internal or external) — Week 1 uses it as a discussion anchor
- Pre-work completed: PM Philosophies, Agile Methodologies, Prompt Engineering primer
- SkillIQ pre-assessments done — Product Management and Data Literacy
- Your triad commitment card

# ? Open Q&A

Common categories of questions to expect at this point:

- "What if my AI access doesn't work?"
- "What happens if I miss a day?"
- "Can our triad change if it's not working?"
- "How is performance evaluated?"
- "What artifacts do I keep after the academy?"



# See You Monday at 09:00

Week 1, Day 1 — AI Fundamentals & Prompting for TPMs